Harbour towns keep their own clocks. Boats leave before dawn and the market opens when they return, whatever the calendar says.

The archive on the hill holds shipping records going back two hundred years, each ledger written in a slightly different hand.

Fog arrives in the afternoon in late autumn, rolling in from the west and settling over the roofs until the evening wind clears it.

Children learn the names of the rocks along the shore before they learn the names of the streets, because the rocks matter more.

A ferry crosses the bay twice a day. In winter it carries more letters than passengers, and the captain knows most of the addresses.

On the northern cape stands a lighthouse that has guided ships for a century, its lamp turning every eleven seconds.

Old maps show a second pier that no longer exists; its stones were reused to build the school, which still stands by the square.

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The keeper's diary describes the storm of the great winter, when the lighthouse was the only light for forty miles.

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Today the lighthouse is automatic, but the town still repaints its white tower every spring as a small celebration.

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